

Chuckie Egg, Jet Set Willy, Bomblack and more.

The best archive of remakes for all formats can be found at <http://retro-remakes.emuunlim.com>. The greatest classics, from arcade games to the Commodore Amiga, have been remade and released here. There are over a hundred free and shareware games to be downloaded, including *Space Invaders*, *Asteroids*, *Boulderdash*, *Centipede*, *PacMan* (in all its incarnations), *Donkey Kong*, *Arkanoid*, *Super Mario Brothers*, *OutRun*, *Attack of the Mutant Camels* and lots more. These remade games are being presented as 'classic games for the next generation'. There are, of course, other remake sites. 'Remakers' are a very vibrant community—they have large Web rings and are well-connected. There's an air of enthusiasm that you can sense in their discussion forums and project announcements.

Game companies themselves release some of their games into the public domain. After all, there's no point hoarding a game that has no commercial value. This helps in increasing the fan base of the franchise, besides keeping the flame of the classics alive. Also, if you enjoy playing *Ultima*, you might just be willing to buy the sequel. Commercial hits of yesteryear such as *Caesar*, *Descent* and *Steel Panthers* are now available as freeware.

Many software companies abandon their old games by not selling or supporting them. Abandonware is any game that is at least three years old and is not being actively sold or supported by the company that produced it or by any other company. Classic gaming enthusiasts distribute such abandonware software themselves. Abandonware Web rings provide software and support to people who have outdated computers.

Emulation

Another source of free games is through emulation. In simple terms, emulation is the act of mimicking the functions of another device. Emulators can mimic any computer or game console on your PC. After installing a console emulation program on your computer, you can load a game ROM—the same game program that came packaged in a cartridge that you might have bought so many years ago—and play it right now on your computer. The advantage here is that you can play pretty much every game ever



Samurai Showdown on the MAME

released for your emulated console (you would still need to get your hand on the game ROMs). The disadvantages range from tangible concerns such as questions of legality and copyright infringement to intangibles such as facing collector scorn—emulated games are not any better than forged artwork. They're not considered the real McCoy even though the programs themselves are perfect digital copies of the original.

Emulators have been around for 20 years or more in one form or another, but it's generally agreed that the first consumer-oriented example was an Apple II emulator for the Commodore Amiga. The early 1990s saw the release of the first commercial game emulators. Since then, the emulation scene has exploded along with the nostalgia gaming movement. A large number of shareware and freeware emulation programs

now exist, from small homebrewed single-console programs to larger, more ambitious multi-console projects such as MESS. Huge community-based projects such as MAME have helped restore thousands of popular arcade games dating from the 1970s to the 1990s. The quality of these emulators range from the almost unworkable, feature crippled, crash-prone beasts that run extremely slowly, to the 'gold-standard' MAME, which is rock solid and runs every game it supports as well as the original arcade machines themselves.

New Classics is the term used to describe new games written for old systems. People are still writing games for the ColecoVision, the Atari 2600, Game Boy and other game systems. Programmers write the game and release it as a ROM image. They don't need to make a cartridge, since freely available emulators can run their game.

Mods

Sooner or later you're bound to get bored with your single player version of *Half-Life*. Rather than simply tossing your game onto a shelf somewhere and forgetting about it, modifications or mods allow you to experience a whole new gaming experience with a few free downloads. One could consider anything that modifies the original game (maps, for example), as a mod. A mod is anything in which some code changes are

The Brief History of Bleem!

Bleem!, the company behind the PC and Dreamcast-based PlayStation emulator of the same name, was shut down in November 2001. Bleem! launched its PlayStation emulator just over two-and-a-half years ago, only to be instantly sued by Sony for a mix of copyright infringement, intellectual property violation and brand degradation.

Bleem! wasn't meant as a substitute for the PlayStation, but it did have its advantages over Sony's console. First, it had the ability to use 3D hardware acceleration to

increase the graphics resolution to PC-quality and second, it let you play games on your PC or laptop.



May 2000 saw the announcement of Bleem!cast, the Dreamcast version of Bleem! Sony sued the company again for patent violations. With the PlayStation

and Xbox code protected against emulation efforts, both legally and through hardware and software-based techniques, Bleem!'s scope for future expansion looks quite bleak.